

Remember Choo-Choo Coleman?

Batting About Phillies' Lore

By ROBERT STRAUSS

Spring training. Magnificence and daffodils and aren't the Phils going to do it again (again?) this year? Rookies and sore-armed resurrections and Mike and Greg and somebody new are going to hit 50 apiece.

Ah, yes, Philadelphians have gotten used to winners. A new localite who blew into town with the Restaurant Renaissance and the Betsy Ross Bridge and Dr. J and all that mod stuff wouldn't even realize the true byword of Philadelphia in the spring: All right, how far behind we gonna finish this season?

A good year was 1960 for loss-oriented Phillies fans. After Robin Roberts pitched the Phearsomes to a 9-4 loss against the Cincinnati Reds on opening day, manager Eddie Sawyer phreaked out and quit. Coach Andy Cohen became the first Jewish big-league manager and won the second game of the season before Gene Mauch took over, leading the Phils to their third consecutive last-place finish.

Local baseball fans (fans?) had been used to last-place finishes, though. Between 1904 and 1960, the Phillies hit bottom 20 times and the Athletics — who moved to Kansas City to lose in 1955 — were last 18 times, including seven straight between 1915 and 1921. From 1935 until 1943, neither team finished better than next to last. Between 1918 and 1948, the Phillies themselves finished as high as fourth only once.

But no one from Villanova to Vineland worth his Valmy Thomas autographed mitt could be prepared for the 1961 debacle.

Having just dropped such stars in the final cut as Marcelino Lopez, Ted Savage, Jim Coker and Paul Brown, the Phillies were set to go against Don Drysdale and the Los Angeles Dodgers before the smallest crowd in L.A.'s opening-day history.

"Imagine," said pitcher Frank Sullivan, who had just been traded from the Red Sox to the Phils, "to come here to be embarrassed at the twilight of a mediocre career."

Bob Sadowski led off and played third base. Tony Curry batted cleanup and played left field. Both were on minor league benches by June. Roberts lost the opener saying, "There's a momentum you can feel."

That momentum carried the Phils to a 30-64 late-July record, which put them a mere 12 games behind Chicago. Problem was that Chicago was in seventh place in an

eight-team league. With nowhere to go but up, the Phils defied Professor Newton and jumped into the great void — they lost their next 23 games.

Nothing could stop the boys in red and white. Third baseman-outfielder Lee Walls had a 15-game hitting streak, but he made six errors afield in precarious moments. The Phils were on the verge of winning one after their 20th loss in Milwaukee, but Jim Owens decided to pitch to Hank Aaron with first base open and ... well, you know.

The Reds, who eventually won the pennant, went so far as to hire a helicopter to dry Crosley Field after a rainstorm so they could fatten up on Phillie marrow — hey, a win's a win, right?

When the Phillies finally did win — a 7-4 victory over the Braves by John Buzhardt (4-13 at the time) — 500 rain-soaked fans showed up at International Airport to greet them at 1 a.m.

"They are selling rocks at \$1.50 a pail," Sullivan told his buddies — who weren't talented enough to catch them anyway.

From this abyss, the Phils dug themselves deeper, finishing 47-107 — last in the hearts of their Brotherly Lovedomites.

"When the stadium survey committee gets around to it," wrote the Daily News' Stan Hochman of the group searching for a site for what became Veterans Stadium, "they ought to consider a telephone booth on the corner of Broad and Locust."

Only 590,039 had shown up at Connie Mack Stadium in 1961 — 2,469 of them for the final 2-0 loss to St. Louis, which wouldn't have been too bad except that the city Recreation Department gave away 5,000 tickets to schoolkids. And who said Philadelphia kids don't have a good education?

So if the Phillies don't meet your glorious expectations this year, just remember Choo-Choo Coleman and Ken Walters and Bobby Gene Smith and Don Ferrarese and Bobby Malkmus and Pancho Herrera and Ken Lehman and Elmer Valo and Charlie Smith and Ruben Gomez and ...